



Trend-setter: From 1999 to 2004, Andrew Leipus served as India's physio and helped raise the team's fitness standards across the board managing players like Javagal Srinath, Ajit Agarkar and Zaheer Khan.

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participation in the Indian Premier League (IPL), where he was representing Delhi Daredevils (now Delhi Capitals). He eventually underwent surgery, which sidelined him for nearly 16 months.

"I had eight stress fractures in my back and three in my foot – so, 11 in total," Aaron says. According to the pacer, body physiology is one of the contributing factors for such injuries. "If your body is predisposed to taking extra load in one part – say, your back – you're more likely to suffer injury. I was born with an

exaggerated arch in my back, called lordosis. Because of that, my spine hinges at the L3 vertebra. My first three or four fractures were in that region."

Certain bowling actions increase this stress, particularly mixed actions (part front-on, part sideways). "In biomechanics, problems arise when there's too much counter-rotation in your bowling action – when your hips and shoulders don't align," the now 35-year-old Aaron explains.

He believes that bowling coaches play a crucial role in the rehab process – a detail often overlooked. "Stress fractures happen because your body is absorbing load unevenly. Fast bowling is inherently unilateral – one side always bears more load. But if you can streamline your action efficiently, you reduce the risk of injury," Aaron explains.

For Pont, the role of a bowling

coach is crucial in a bowler's life right from the grassroots, since the bodies of athletes under the age of 25 are still developing. "Fifteen to nineteen years of age is the highest incidence of lumbar stress fracture," he notes. "It's the most vulnerable age group since spines are still developing – vertebrae don't fully ossify until around 21–23 years."

Young bowlers often play year-round with high workloads but underdeveloped strength and poor recovery habits. If coupled with poor technique, this creates a perfect storm for injury. A study on English County Cricket fast bowlers between 2010 and 2016 showed that 368 pacers reported 57 lumbar stress fractures, with a mean age of 22.8 years.

"Coaches don't often adjust the technique, especially at the club and low level. I don't blame them; they